

Chapter – 9: Family and Community

Love and dharma are the flower and fruit of family life. — Thiruvalluvar

Family

- All of us – live in family – fundamental, most ancient unit – any society
- Indian society today – families – several types –
 - Joint families – several generations – live together – grandparents, parents, uncles, aunts, brothers, sisters, cousins
 - Nuclear families – limited – 1 couple and their children
- English – nit many terms – describe family relations
- Indian languages – many more terms –
 - Hindi – *bua, tau, tai, chacha, mausi, nana, nani*, etc.
 - Tamil – diff. terms – elder brother / sister OR younger brother / sister
- Indian languages – cousin – no special word – cousins – also brothers and sisters – emphasis – deep bonds – all children

Roles and Responsibilities

- Relations – family members – based on – love, care, cooperation, interdependence
- Each member – role, responsibility – towards other members
- Parents – responsible – raising children – become happy individuals, responsible members
- BUT – as children grow – take on more responsibility – help other members
- Daily practice – children learn – participate – life of household
- Many homes – children – learn traditions, practices – their family – following for generations
- Following Dharma (duty) – imp. principle – Indian culture
- Family – kind of school – children learn – imp. values – ahimsa, *dana* (giving), *seva* (service), *tyaga* (sacrifice)
- Individuals in family – give up – own needs – take care – family needs
- One such story –
 - Shalini – lives with family – town – Kerala
 - Father – small businessman – mother – school teacher
 - Family members – younger brother, Acchamma (father's mother), Chittappa (paternal uncle), Chitti (uncle's wife)
 - Uncle, Aunt – daughter – Shalini's cousin – Chinni
 - Her uncle – lost his job – aunt – homemaker
 - Whole family – preparing for Onam
 - Acchamma – told her father – uncle – financial difficulties – no new clothes for festival
 - Shalini's parents – clothes shopping – buy for Chittappa, Chitti, Chinni also
 - Result – Shalini expected silk dress – BUT – got cotton dress
 - Acchamma – explained – families – support each other – this way
 - Shalini – happy – everyone – new dress
- Let's travel northeast – village in Meghalaya –
 - Main character – Tenzing – lives in mountains – love them – BUT – life tough sometimes
 - Father – small grocery store owner

- Mother – busy – local handicraft cooperative – making – traditional fabrics, wood carvings, other items – sale – tourist
- Father – helped around house – cleaning, taking care of vegetable garden, other household chores
- Often – helps grandmother – prepare food
- Grandmother – interesting stories – humor, wisdom – can read people – very well
- Grandfather – helps with homework – takes him to school bus stop
- Also – actively involved – social work – always helping others
- Example –
 - Power failure – lodged complaint – nearby office
 - Storm – neighbor's house – damaged – collected money – help with repairs
- Family – very lucky – parents – take care – basic needs – food, clothing
- Special expense – parents – discuss together
- Mother says – always try – save money – unexpected needs

Community

- Families – connected within themselves – ALSO – connected to other families
- Such grp. – connected people – community
- Members – come together – various reasons – celebrating festivals, organizing feasts, wedding, etc.
- Some villages – people – come together – support each other – agriculture – land preparation, sowing, harvesting
- Over time – communities – agreed – some practices – use shared resources – water, grazing lands, forest produce – especially tribal communities
- Even today – rural India – village communities – follow these practices
- Such practices – may be 'rules' – rarely written down – provided – secure access – resources
- Also means – all families – specific duties – otherwise – community – not func. properly
- Jhabua, Madhya Pradesh –
 - Acute water crisis
 - Bhil community – plant 1000s of trees – 100s of villages – support everyone – follow *halma* tradition
 - Also dug – many trenches – conserve rainwater – created other water harvesting structures
 - This work – no payment – BUT – serving env.
 - *Halma* tradition – obj. – serve Mother Earth
 - 2019 – Shri Mahesh Sharma – Shivganga movement – honored with – Padma Shri award – outstanding work – Bhil communities
- Chennai –
 - Chennai floods – 2015 – roads – turned to rivers – people – no movement
 - All shops – closed – service – interrupted
 - Private grp. – especially spiritual, religious organisations – cooked – large quantities of food – distribute
- Real-life stories – show community – rural context
- Community – also present – urban context – func. differently
- Another real-life story –
 - 20+ yrs. ago – Ahmedabad (Gujarat)
 - Kamal Parmar – small auto-fabrication workshop – noticed – grp. – underprivileged kids
 - Some – dropped out – others – never went to school

- Kamal – gave them tuition – 5:30 to 9:30 PM – after regular work hrs.
- Also provided – free diner
- Soon – 150 children – attending classes – deeply interested
- Few teachers – local school – started teaching there
- One of them obs. –
 - These children – no benches, noisy classrooms – YET – pay attention
 - Love and affection – unbelievable
- Older children – regular schools – volunteered – Kamal's classes
- One of them – we went to teach, instead, we learnt a lot
- New type – community – last 30–40 yrs.
- Residents' Welfare Associations – urban areas – make their own rules and regulations
- These rules – waste management, cleanliness, pets, etc.
- People – living there – participate – making rules
- Communities – interdependent – each other
- Complex societies – everyone – depend on – no. of other people, communities